interests with the United States on a number of international issues. Nevertheless, from the mid-1990s, Beijing's fears about the new sole superpower position of the United States grew rapidly, both with regard to its global capabilities as well as US success in keeping its Cold War alliance partners and strengthening its forward posture in East Asia.[72] As China was not in a position to balance the United States, it developed what Avery Goldstein has called a "strategy of transition"; something in between balancing against and bandwagoning with the United States.[73] According to Goldstein, the strategy was moulded as a response to US unipolarity, and it would most likely change as soon as China had risen, hence a strategy of transition.

Implementing a strategy of transition, China adhered to Deng Xiaoping's doctrine of "keeping a low profile" in international affairs, reassuring its neigh-bours of its peaceful intentions and avoiding a "China Threat" perception taking root in other countries in the region, all in order to sustain a peaceful environment necessary for growth.[74] China also attempted to build relations with other major powers, preparing for a more multipolar international system with China as one of the poles.

A strategic partnership agreement with Russia in 1996 was followed by a Sino–Russian "Joint Declaration on a Multipolar World" the next year,[75] and Beijing managed to craft a convincing reassurance policy vis-à-vis Russia.[76] Although India also had a common interest with China in opposing American dominance in world politics,[77] China was not able to draw India into its orbit in the same way as with Russia. In the official statement by India's Prime Minister Vajpayee confirming the nuclear tests in 1998, he had made a blunt reference to the distrust in India's relationship with China, leaving no doubt that security concerns towards China were an important motivating factor for going nuclear.[78]